

I28

John the apostle

A "son of thunder" who became the apostle of love.

John was a Galilean fisherman, the son of Zebedee and brother of James, and one of Jesus' inner circle. In the first three Gospels he is fiery: he stops a stranger casting out devils and wants fire on a Samaritan village. In Acts he stands beside Peter, unafraid before the council, and Paul calls him a pillar of the church. Tradition identifies him with "the disciple whom Jesus loved" and credits him with a Gospel, three letters and Revelation. These are still discussed, but his story shows zeal reshaped by love.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Yochanan</i> , "the LORD is gracious"
Family	Son of Zebedee; brother of James; mother probably Salome
Work	Fisherman, partner of Simon Peter (Luke 5:10)
Nickname	With James, Boanerges, "the sons of thunder" (Mark 3:17)
Key people	Peter; James; Mary, mother of Jesus; Paul
Known as	Traditionally "the disciple whom Jesus loved" (John 13:23)
Writings	Traditionally John, 1–3 John, Revelation; debated
Later life	Tradition says he lived to old age at Ephesus

"Now when they saw the boldness of Peter and John, and perceived that they were unlearned and ignorant men, they marvelled; and they took knowledge of them, that they had been with Jesus."

Acts 4:13, KJV

The life of John the apostle

Dates are approximate (AD). The crucifixion is dated AD 30 or AD 33; this study uses c. AD 30. The Patmos date follows tradition; some prefer c. AD 68.

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| c. AD 28
<i>Sea of Galilee</i> | ● Called with his brother
Jesus calls James and John from mending nets, and they leave Zebedee to follow him. <i>Mark 1:19–20</i> |
| c. AD 29
<i>On a high mountain</i> | ● Sees the Transfiguration
John, Peter and James see Jesus shine with glory and hear the Father's voice from the cloud. <i>Mark 9:2–8</i> |
| c. AD 30
<i>Road to Jerusalem</i> | ● Asks for glory
John and James ask for the seats at Jesus' right and left. Jesus teaches that the greatest must be the servant of all. <i>Mark 10:35–45</i> |
| c. AD 30
<i>Jerusalem</i> | ● At the supper and the cross
Peter and John prepare the Passover. At the cross Jesus entrusts his mother to "the disciple whom Jesus loved," traditionally John. <i>Luke 22:8–13; John 19:25–27</i> |
| c. AD 30
<i>The empty tomb</i> | ● Runs and believes
Told the tomb is empty, Peter and the beloved disciple run to it. The other disciple arrives first, goes in after Peter, sees, and believes. <i>John 20:1–10</i> |
| Soon after Pentecost
<i>Jerusalem</i> | ● Arrested with Peter
After the healing of a lame man at the temple gate, Peter and John are jailed and questioned. They refuse to stop speaking about Jesus. <i>Acts 3:1–4:22</i> |
| c. AD 46–49
<i>Jerusalem</i> | ● Counted a pillar
Paul names James, Cephas and John as pillars of the church, who give him and Barnabas the right hand of fellowship. <i>Galatians 2:9</i> |
| c. AD 95
<i>Patmos</i> | ● Sees the Revelation
A servant of Christ named John, exiled on the island of Patmos, receives visions for seven churches in Asia. Tradition identifies him as the apostle. <i>Revelation 1:1, 9–11</i> |

Key activities

Several scenes below involve "the disciple whom Jesus loved." John's Gospel never names him. Since the second century most Christians have identified him as John; some scholars suggest another follower, such as Lazarus or an unknown Jerusalem disciple.

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- I Left his nets.** He and James left their father and the boat to follow Jesus. *Mark 1:19-20*

 - 2 Was named a son of thunder.** Jesus gave the brothers the name Boanerges. *Mark 3:17*

 - 3 Forbade a stranger.** He stopped one casting out devils in Jesus' name; Jesus said, "Forbid him not." *Luke 9:49-50*

 - 4 Wanted fire from heaven.** He and James wanted to call down fire on a Samaritan village, and Jesus rebuked them. *Luke 9:51-56*

 - 5 Asked for honor.** He and James asked for the best seats in the kingdom. *Mark 10:35-41*

 - 6 Prepared the Passover.** Jesus sent Peter and John to make ready the last supper. *Luke 22:8-13*

 - 7 Leaned on Jesus at supper.** The beloved disciple, reclining next to Jesus, asked who would betray him. *John 13:23-26*

 - 8 Took Mary home.** From the cross Jesus said to the disciple, "Behold thy mother!" and he took her into his home. *John 19:26-27*

 - 9 Recognized the risen Lord.** At the miraculous catch the beloved disciple said to Peter, "It is the Lord." *John 21:4-7*

 - 10 Spoke boldly.** Ordered to be silent, Peter and John said they could not stop speaking what they had seen and heard. *Acts 4:13-20*

 - 11 Went to Samaria.** Once eager for fire on Samaritans, he prayed there for believers to receive the Spirit. *Acts 8:14-17*

 - 12 Wrote so others would believe.** His traditional Gospel was written "that ye might believe." *John 20:30-31*

Across Scripture

Tradition (Irenaeus, c. AD 180): John wrote the Gospel at Ephesus and lived into Trajan's reign. Others credit the beloved disciple's circle or "John the elder"; Revelation's John does not call himself an apostle.

Old Testament

Exodus 12:46; Zechariah 12:10	Fulfilled at the cross (John 19:35–37)
Echo: Genesis 1:1; Daniel 7	"In the beginning"; Revelation draws on Daniel and Ezekiel

New Testament

Mark 3:17; 5:37; 9:2; 10:35–45	Inner circle and son of thunder
John 13:23; 19:26; 21:20–24	The beloved disciple, who "wrote these things"
Acts 3:1–4:22; 8:14–25	With Peter in Jerusalem and Samaria
Galatians 2:9	A pillar of the church
1 John 4:7–8; 2 John 1	"Let us love one another," from "the elder"

For discussion

- Observe:* What did the council notice about Peter and John (Acts 4:13)?
- Understand:* John once wanted fire on Samaria, then prayed there for the Spirit. What changed him?
- Apply:* Where are you tempted to dismiss believers who "followeth not with us"?
- Apply:* Who has God placed in your care this season, as Jesus entrusted Mary to John?